

CoARA Action Plan 2025 – 2028

SETU September 2025

**Office of Research, Innovation and
Impact
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1. Introduction and context

South East Technological University (SETU), a multi campus institution, established on May 1st 2022. With over 19,000 students and 1,800 staff research and innovation is a core activity at SETU and is one of our main connection points with industry, the public sector and the community. The [Strategic Plan Connecting for Impact 2023-2028](#) sets out an overarching strategic goal for the University to become a “research-led organisation with a demonstrably impactful, innovative, and dynamic research community”. The SETU priority areas of research and diverse research units are detailed in the Research, Innovation and Impact (RII) strategic plan [Connecting Research to Impact 2025-2028](#). An elevation of R&I activity and underpinning support structures is mandated by the Technological University Act 2018 and is a core objective of the SETU RII strategic plan. As a new type of University in Ireland, the Technological University sector does not yet have a formal research career and assessment system in place and this Action plan aims to advance progress towards that goal.

Internationally, Research performing and Research funding organisations have long been searching for new criteria that can enhance and reward the quality of research. Common points of discussion include (but are not limited to) the development of new indicators that go beyond quantitative indicators and recognising criteria such as open science, valorisation of research results, engagement and research impact, equal opportunities, peer review and other service, quality, and transparency. Core underpinning elements include recruitment, promotion and awards.

Institutional changes will lead to the reform of Research Assessment processes, greater recognition of diverse research outputs driving excellence, new and/or improved services, products, tools, capacity-building programmes, processes, and practice-change supporting impactful research that addresses complex economic, environmental, and societal challenges. In line with this, SETU endorsed the initiative “Coalition for Advancing of Research Evaluation (CoARA)” and signed the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment (ARRA) in May 2023. It is widely acknowledged that a reform of research assessment practices, specifically considering research quality, integrity, accountability and impact is needed. Research assessment and peer review should consider both appropriate qualitative and quantitative indicators for all disciplines.

2. Approach to implementing CoARA at SETU

As a signatory of CoARA in 2023 and the preceding DORA (Declaration on Research Assessment) in 2020, SETU promotes responsible research assessment, incorporating a holistic emphasis on the quality of diverse activities and outputs from different disciplines. SETU’s commitment as a CoARA signatory includes designing assessment criteria and processes that emphasise quality, impact, diversity and inclusiveness. This ethos underpins the annual Research excellence awards evaluation process, recognising excellent, impactful research and supervision by staff across the university. Research excellence awards have been run at SETU (at the predecessor institution Waterford Institute of Technology) since 2021. DORA compliant CVs and a qualitative narrative are utilised for applications as well as for Internal funding calls and PhD scholarships. All such awards involve evaluation by a combination of internal and external experts.

ARRA principles are embedded in SETU policies governing research conduct and broad consultations were conducted and feedback obtained from staff across all disciplines in

their development. The Contributor Roles Taxonomy (CRediT) is a high-level taxonomy, including 14 roles which describe each contributor's specific contribution to the scholarly output and is an underpinning principle of the SETU Authorship policy. CRediT is increasingly being adopted by publishers as a mechanism to provide structured, interoperable data on the diversity of contributions of different authors and support research attribution, provenance and integrity.

At SETU adherence with the highest standards of research integrity in the conduct of research is a priority. SETU staff, researchers and students are expected to comply with relevant regulations and the "[Code of Conduct for Responsible Research Practice](#)". SETU is a signatory of the *National Action Plan for Open Research 2022-2030*, a primary objective being to achieve 100% open access to research publications by 2030. The SETU Open research policy was approved in 2024. With a view to conducting societally relevant and accessible research and innovation SETU provides training in the implementation of the Open research policy. Currently, over 50% of research publications are in Open access journals.

SETU is committed to embedding CoARA and DORA principles into all stages of the researcher lifecycle, beginning with recruitment and selection. This includes ensuring that hiring practices move beyond narrow publication metrics and embrace qualitative assessments, narrative CVs, and recognition of diverse research contributions. In partnership with Human Resources and the Office of Equality, Diversity and Inclusion, SETU have developed inclusive recruitment guidance and selection/interview panel training to ensure fairness, transparency, and alignment with national and international best practice.

3. Research and research culture at SETU

As a research-led university SETU aims to deepen its culture of research by embedding research in all undergraduate programmes and ensuring strong linkages between teaching and research. We will consolidate and strengthen our support infrastructure for researchers in order to better support high-quality research and scholarship. We are informed in our planning in relation to Innovation and Research by our governing legislation which identifies several performance targets that require the elevation of research activity, graduate student recruitment and staff PhD qualifications across the university. As set out in the Research, Innovation and Impact (RII) strategy *Connecting Research to Impact 2025-2028* we aim to increase the quantity and quality of our research outputs with a particular focus on high-quality research publications, industry relevance, knowledge transfer and societal impact.

At SETU a multidisciplinary research approach is critical to answer complex problems, open new areas of research, increase efficiency and to build collaboration across research disciplines, SETU campuses and also with external partners. SETU Waterford has held the "HR Excellence in Research" Award from the European Commission (EC), which recognises institutional practices in place to support researchers' career and professional development in line with the European Charter for Researchers and The Code of Conduct for the Recruitment of Researchers, since 2014. The award acknowledges SETU for providing attractive working conditions and equipping researchers with the broad skills and experience necessary to develop their careers. This designation is a clear statement

of our dedication to provide an excellent and supportive environment to researchers. A suite of training courses and wellbeing initiatives, including the Broaden Your Horizons programme and Odyssey mentoring programme, are held annually. The Broaden Your Horizons programme is tailored specifically to early- and mid-career researchers and offers practical, cohort-based development pathways that address skills, career planning, and professional identity in a supportive and collaborative environment.

The present document (considered as a living document) represents SETU’s commitment to implementing the ARRA principles, taking into account synergies with the RII strategic plan and previous commitments of the European Commission’s Human Resources Strategy for Researchers (HRS4R) strategy to support the careers of researchers, fostering a supportive and inclusive culture of research excellence. As articulated in the RII strategy “we commit to growing and supporting a positive and healthy research culture and environment that instils core values relating to ambition, scholarship, creativity and transformational impact across all campuses”.

4. Actions taken post-CoARA agreement signature

Several actions have been delivered since signing the agreement in May 2023, those relevant to the Action plan have been incorporated into Table 2, below.

- Engagement of specialised TU RISE staff to provide tailored support in recruitment and training
- Development and provision of Impact-related training
- Expansion of the Open research and Open Data training offerings, in collaboration with Library staff
- Launch of a new research sabbatical scheme, in collaboration with enterprise
- Launch of a SETU staff awards scheme, recognising the contributions of support staff and technicians
- Roll out of PURE (SETU’s Current Research Information System) across all campuses, enabling the showcasing of researchers’ achievements and improved tracking of research funding and outputs.

5. Working group membership and objectives

In order to further advance the ARRA commitments at SETU a Working group, comprising the members shown in the table below, was established in 2025.

Table 1. CoARA Working group members

Name	Role
Dr Geraldine Canny	Head of Research, Chair
Ms Breda Connell	Deputy Librarian
Dr Saoirse Cummins	Engaged Research, Impact and Policy Officer

Dr Alan Davy	Head of Department of Computing
Ms Eimear Fitzpatrick	HR Business Partner for Research
Ms Susie Cullinane	Senior Project Coordinator
Mr David Kane	Deputy Librarian
Dr Allison Kenneally	Vice President for Equality, Diversity & Inclusion
Ms Jane Mahony	Human Resources Manager

The objectives of this Working group are to:

- Identify barriers and areas to be addressed regarding Research assessment in SETU
- Contribute to the development of a CoARA action plan
- Raise awareness regarding Research culture and assessment
- Support the implementation and monitoring of the CoARA action plan
- Support the integration of career development and progression opportunities into research assessment reform, including structured pathways for ECRs and research staff.

The action plan is led by the Office of the Vice President for Research, Innovation and Impact (RII), in collaboration with members of the Executive management team, in particular the Vice President for People, Culture and Equality, Diversity and Inclusion. The plan is implemented by RII staff in collaboration with researchers across all Faculties, with feedback obtained after training and other events to ensure continuous improvement, in line with CoARA commitment 10. The Plan will introduce structured mechanisms for recognizing diverse impact (commitment 1) and promote cultural change towards inclusive evaluation via training and communication (commitment 9).

6. CoARA Action Plan

The Plan comprises actions, each aligned with the relevant commitment or ARRA principle. The actions listed in the table below are also aligned with the following priority areas of the SETU RII strategic plan:

- Priority Area One: Strengthening and diversifying research, innovation and knowledge transfer.
- Priority Area Two: People, research culture and environment.

This Action Plan will be amended with changes to legislation and other external regulations as well as SETU policies and procedures, where applicable.

Table 2. CoARA Actions, Implementation and Timelines

ARRA commitment/ principle	Implementation details at SETU	Timeline /Completed by
Recognise the diversity contributions and careers of to, in, research	Organise initiatives (seminars, workshops) on the thematic of results dissemination and exploitation, engagement and open research, open access	Commenced in 2023, ongoing
	Provide training on diverse outputs e.g. Podcast training	Implement in 2026
	Impact case study annual competition and dedicated impact webpage showcasing and celebrating impactful research.	Commenced in 2025
	Annual open research publication/output award	Implement in 2026
	Create a dashboard for open research practices, showcasing diverse research outputs	Implement in 2026
Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use	Provide tailored workshops and seminars for researchers at specific career stages (e.g. Broaden your Horizon programme, TU RISE training)	Commenced in 2023, ongoing
	Provide training on Research integrity, ethics, Export controls, Intellectual property rights, and data management to increase awareness of professional responsibility	Commenced in 2023-2024, ongoing
	PURE training on profile creation and capturing diverse research outputs	Commenced in 2023, ongoing
	Promote Use of Persistent Identifiers (PIDs) via PURE	Commenced in 2025, ongoing
	All PhD Research and Training plans to include dissemination and communication training	Implement in 2026
	Organise initiatives (seminars, workshops) on the thematic of results dissemination and exploitation and open research, open access	Commenced in 2023, ongoing
	Engaged research training and encouraging/supporting engagement and involvement of external stakeholders in research.	Commenced in 2024, ongoing
	70% of SETU researchers received Impact training	Commenced in 2024, ongoing

	Support in developing impactful proposals through Theory of Change (ToC) workshops specific to funding calls	Commenced in 2025, ongoing
	Equality, Diversity and Inclusion training for researchers	Commenced in 2023, ongoing
	Narrative CV training for researchers across disciplines at all career stages	Implement in 2026
	Integrate Narrative CV Elements into PURE Profiles	Implement in 2026
Review and development of research assessment criteria, tools and processes	Development of methodologies for impact assessment	Implement in 2026
	Review the <i>Definition and Organisation of Research units</i> policy to ensure it captures current trends and “balanced” evaluation processes	Implement in 2026
	Develop a researcher career framework - In alignment with the European Charter for Researchers, the HR Strategy for Researchers (HRS4R), and the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment (ARRA). This framework will provide clarity, structure, and transparency for career development and progression across all research roles — including academic, research-only, technical, and hybrid positions.	Implement in 2027
	Enable Peer Review and Societal Engagement Recording in PURE	Commenced in 2025, ongoing
	Establishment of a SETU publication and data repository	Implement in 2026
	Produce a procedure document to implement ARRA practices recognising diverse research profiles and outputs	Implement in 2027
	Updating/completing all PURE researcher profiles to include non-traditional outputs	Completed by end 2027
Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning with and beyond the Coalition	Successfully obtain funding under CoARA boost and commence project	Completed by end 2028

7. Implementation, Review and Communication

This Action Plan requires broad support and engagement across SETU for implementation, actions will be driven by RII office staff in close collaboration with Human Resources and Library staff, in particular. Several of these actions will be progressed by TU RISE-funded staff, with continuous data collection conducted in

tandem with relevant training. These activities build on previous and ongoing initiatives, including HRS4R.

These actions are firmly grounded in SETU's ongoing commitment to the principles of the European Commission's Human Resources Strategy for Researchers (HRS4R). They build on progress made through previous and current initiatives under HRS4R and reflect our institution-wide dedication to fostering a supportive, inclusive, and research-enabling environment. As part of this commitment, SETU is actively developing a new HRS4R Action Plan that will shape and align with our strategic goals for researcher development, career progression, and research culture enhancement.

The timing of this work is particularly significant, as SETU is preparing to reapply for the HR Excellence in Research Award in December 2025. The actions outlined within this plan will directly inform and support that reapplication, demonstrating our ongoing alignment with the principles of the European Charter for Researchers and the Code of Conduct for the Recruitment of Researchers, and our ambition to continuously strengthen our research environment. SETU commits to strengthening recruitment and selection processes, to promote inclusive hiring practices and to recognising diverse researcher profiles.

The effectiveness of SETU's career development initiatives will be monitored through annual surveys, PURE data, and programme evaluations. Key performance indicators (KPIs) include:

- % of researchers with a completed Personal Development Plan (PDP)
- Participation rate in the ODYSSEY mentoring programme and structured development activities
- Retention rate of researchers, disaggregated by career stage and role type
- Progression rates into permanent, leadership, or independently funded roles
- Researcher satisfaction with development opportunities (via annual survey).

In line with Commitment 9, progress made on the implementation of the commitments will be monitored and communicated. Progress on the Action plan will be reviewed annually and a report sent to the President and Executive management team and once approved subsequently sent to all staff. An annual webinar detailing activities and outcomes over the preceding year will also be organised. The PURE system will be integral to monitoring and reporting activities. Training activities will incorporate surveys and iterative improvements made based on assessments and feedback received. As such, success indicators include improved enhanced accuracy/timeliness of captured outputs in PURE; increased researcher capabilities and satisfaction (measured via surveys/feedback).

As a member of CoARA, SETU will communicate progress made and exchange good practice with other members of the Coalition, via membership of the CoARA national platform and membership of Working groups.

Glossary of Terms

CoARA - Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment

Established to implement the **Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment (ARRA)**. It brings together institutions committed to transforming research assessment by recognising diverse outputs, emphasising qualitative peer review, and supporting open science. As a CoARA signatory, SETU has pledged to develop and implement an action plan that aligns institutional practices with the core ARRA commitments.

ARRA - Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment

This shared framework was developed through a broad consultation process led by the European Commission. ARRA outlines **ten core commitments** that emphasise quality over quantity, responsible use of metrics, recognition of a diversity of research contributions, and support for open science practices.

DORA - San Francisco Declaration on Research Assessment

DORA is a global initiative launched in 2013 that calls for improved research assessment practices by discouraging reliance on journal-based metrics such as impact factors. It advocates for the evaluation of research on its own merits, using a broader set of qualitative and quantitative indicators. As a DORA signatory, SETU is committed to implementing responsible metrics and fostering a culture that values diverse contributions to research and scholarship.

CRIS - Current Research Information System

An institutional platform, PURE, is used to report on outputs, projects, funding, and researcher profiles. At SETU, the CRIS is implemented through **PURE**. While PURE supports internal performance monitoring and external visibility, it complements — but does not replace — the role of an institutional **Open Repository**, which is essential for long-term preservation, legal deposit, and open access compliance.

CRedit - Contributor Roles Taxonomy

CRedit is a high-level taxonomy developed to provide transparency in scholarly publishing by clearly identifying the kinds of individual contributions made to research outputs by each author. It defines **14 standardised contributor roles**—such as Conceptualization, Methodology, Data Curation, Writing – Original Draft, and Supervision—allowing precise attribution beyond authorship order.

HRS4R - Human Resources Strategy for Researchers

HRS4R is a European Commission initiative that supports research institutions in implementing the principles of the [European Charter for Researchers and the Code of Conduct for the Recruitment of Researchers \(2005\)](#). Its aim is to foster attractive and supportive research environments through fair recruitment, career development, and working conditions. SETU holds the **HR Excellence in Research** Award, reflecting its commitment to continuous improvement in researcher support.

PURE - Research information management system (Elsevier's platform used at SETU)
See **CRIS**, above.

OA - Open Access

Open Access refers to the free, immediate, and unrestricted online availability of scholarly research outputs, allowing any user to read, download, copy, distribute, or use them with proper attribution. OA is a foundational component of **Open Science**, which includes open data, open methods, and open peer review, and is essential for maximising the visibility, accessibility, and impact of research.